



The Constitution

The founding charter of the Society of Arts and Letters:
who we are, how we decide, and how we carry on

For ratification at the Founding General Assembly on Charter Day, Tuesday, October 13, 2026

Prepared by

Shaheen Farjo

Founder & President

PREAMBLE

We, students of the American University of Iraq – Baghdad, gathered as the Society of Arts and Letters, in a city that once kept the House of Wisdom and still keeps al-Mutanabbi Street, adopt this Constitution so that our Society is open to every student, governed in the open, careful with people and money, and built to outlast those who founded it.

OUR MOTTO

والقراطس والقلم

The paper and the pen

From al-Mutanabbi's most quoted line: *the horses, the night and the desert know me; so do the sword, the lance, the paper and the pen. We keep only the last two.*

OUR MISSION

To cultivate a culture of literature and creative expression across AUIB.

OUR FOUR PILLARS

Connecting students
Fostering creativity
Celebrating culture
Building a community

How to read this document

The Constitution holds the rules that should rarely change: purpose, membership, who holds power, and how that power is checked. Everyday procedure lives in the Bylaws (SAL-GOV-02), role descriptions in the Roles & Staffing Handbook (SAL-GOV-03), and conduct, money and media rules in the Policy Manual (SAL-POL-01).

At a Glance

The whole Constitution on one page, for members who will never read the other ten.

Open and free

Any enrolled AUIB student can join. No fee, no audition, no portfolio. Members who take part in two activities a semester vote.

Members hold the power

The General Assembly of all members elects the officers, changes this Constitution and can remove anyone who abuses a role.

A Council runs the work

Four elected officers and six appointed directors meet every two weeks, adopt the budget and greenlight programmes.

Elections every April

Secret ballot with AUIB sign-in, run by a committee of non-candidates. Ranked choice when more than two stand. Presidents serve two terms at most.

Editors decide the art

Programme editors and directors make creative calls. The Council overrules a selection only on grounds of law, safety or University policy, and in writing.

Every dinar is logged

Spending limits, two people on every cash count, receipts for everything, and charity money passed on in full.

Fair process

Anyone facing discipline hears the concern and can answer it. Removal of an officer needs two-thirds of members voting.

Written to last

Minutes, reports and an archive are kept for the next generation. Core principles can only be changed at two meetings, a month apart.

DECISION	WHO DECIDES	THRESHOLD
Amend the Constitution	General Assembly	Two-thirds of votes cast, 14 days' notice
Change the Bylaws or a Policy	Council	Two-thirds of Council; members may overturn by majority
Elect the officers	Voting Members	Annual election in April
Appoint the directors	Executive Board, confirmed by Council	After an open call and interview
Spend within the budget	Director + Treasurer / President + Treasurer / Council	Up to 50,000 / 250,000 / above 250,000 IQD

The Articles

Article I Name, Status and Symbols

- 1.1 The name of the organisation is the **Society of Arts and Letters**, in Arabic جمعية الفنون والآداب, known as **SAL** and in full as the AUIB Society of Arts and Letters ("the Society").
- 1.2 The Society is a registered student organisation of the American University of Iraq – Baghdad ("the University"), recognised by the Office of Student Life. It follows the University's policies; where this Constitution and University policy differ, University policy prevails.
- 1.3 The Society's symbols are the Key monogram, the colours crimson, white and ink, and the motto *The paper and the pen* (القرطاش والقلم). The Society Typewriter is its ceremonial object and is held in the custody of the President.
- 1.4 English and Arabic are the languages of the Society and stand on equal footing in its work. This Constitution is authoritative in English; an Arabic summary is attached.
- 1.5 The Society was founded by Shaheen Farjo in [month, year]. This Constitution was adopted on Charter Day, October 13, 2026.

Article II Purpose

- 2.1 The mission of the Society is to cultivate a culture of literature and creative expression across AUIB.
- 2.2 The Society pursues four pillars: connecting students, fostering creativity, celebrating culture, and building a community.
- 2.3 It does so through publishing, readings and salons, workshops, theatre, exhibitions, film and media, charitable programmes, and partnerships with other clubs, departments and cultural institutions.

- 2.4 The Society is non-partisan and non-sectarian. It does not campaign for any party, candidate or sect. Creative work presented by the Society may explore any human theme, within University policy and the law.
- 2.5 The Society is not for profit. Its funds serve its purpose only. No member receives payment or profit from Society funds, apart from reimbursement of approved expenses.

Article III Membership

- 3.1 Membership is open to every enrolled student of the University. It is free, and requires no audition, portfolio or fee.
- 3.2 A student becomes a Member by completing the registration form and signing the Member Pledge.
- 3.3 The categories of membership are:
 - (a) **Member:** any registered student.
 - (b) **Voting Member:** a Member in good standing who has taken part in at least two Society activities in the current or previous semester, as recorded in the register.
 - (c) **Fellow:** a Member honoured by the Council for sustained or outstanding service.
 - (d) **Honorary Member:** a member of faculty, staff, an alumnus or a guest writer or artist, named by two-thirds of the Council. Honorary Members do not vote.
 - (e) **Alumni Member:** a former Member who has graduated. Alumni Members do not vote.

- 3.4** No one shall be excluded from membership, office or any activity of the Society on the grounds of gender, ethnicity, religion, sect, language, nationality, disability, college or year of study, or any other ground protected by University policy.
- 3.5** Every Member may attend Society activities, propose programmes, apply for any role, see the minutes and accounts, and raise a concern without fear of retaliation. Voting Members may vote and stand for office.
- 3.6** Every Member agrees to follow the Code of Conduct, to respect the work and consent of others, and to handle the Society's property and money honestly.
- 3.7** Membership ends by written resignation, by graduation (when the Member becomes an Alumni Member), or by removal under Article XII.

Article IV Structure

- 4.1** The Society acts through the General Assembly, the Council, the Faculty Advisor, its Programmes and its Committees.
- 4.2** All authority in the Society comes from the General Assembly of its Members.

Article V The General Assembly

- 5.1** The General Assembly is made up of all Members. Only Voting Members may vote.
- 5.2** The General Assembly elects the officers, amends this Constitution, receives the Annual Report and accounts, may amend or overturn any Bylaw or Policy, may remove an officer, and may dissolve the Society.
- 5.3** The General Assembly meets at least once each semester. The Annual General Meeting is held in the spring. An Extraordinary General Assembly is called by the President, by a majority of the Council, or by a petition of one-tenth of Voting Members (and no fewer than ten), and meets within fourteen days of the petition.

- 5.4** Notice of a General Assembly, with its agenda, is sent to all Members at least seven days before it meets, and at least fourteen days before if an amendment to this Constitution is proposed.
- 5.5** The quorum is one-fifth of Voting Members or fifteen Voting Members, whichever is fewer.
- 5.6** Decisions are taken by a simple majority of votes cast, unless this Constitution says otherwise. Members may vote in person or through a secure online form that requires AUIB sign-in.

Article VI The Council

- 6.1** The Council is made up of the Executive Board (the President, Vice President, General Secretary and Treasurer) and six Directors: of Letters; of Stage and Arts; of Programmes and Events; of Media; of Partnerships and Outreach; and of Membership and Community.
- 6.2** The Faculty Advisor, the Founding Advisor (Article VIII) and, when their programme is discussed, the Programme Chairs attend without a vote.
- 6.3** The Council runs the Society between General Assemblies. It adopts the budget, greenlights and closes programmes, appoints Programme Chairs, adopts Bylaws and Policies, and names Fellows and Honorary Members.
- 6.4** The Council meets at least every two weeks during term. Its quorum is a majority of its seated members, including the President or the Vice President. Decisions are taken by a majority of those voting; the chair has a casting vote in a tie.
- 6.5** Minutes and a log of decisions are made available to Members within seven days, except for confidential matters such as conduct cases and personal data.

- 6.6** While the Society is small, the Council may combine two Director roles in one person or leave one vacant, recording the reason in its minutes. No person holds more than one Council seat.

Article VII Officers and Directors

- 7.1 The President** leads the Society, chairs the Council and the General Assembly, represents the Society to the University and beyond, serves ex officio as Publisher of the Society's journal, and keeps the Society Typewriter.
- 7.2 The Vice President** deputises for the President, oversees the Directors' work plans, and chairs the Conduct Panel.
- 7.3 The General Secretary** keeps the minutes, records, register and archive, conducts correspondence with the Office of Student Life, and administers elections.
- 7.4 The Treasurer** keeps the accounts, prepares the budget, enforces the rules on money, and reports on the finances to the Council each month and to the General Assembly each year.
- 7.5 Directors** lead the Society's departments. They are appointed by the Executive Board after an open call and interview, and confirmed by the Council.
- 7.6** The term of office is one academic year, from the handover in May to the next. No person may serve more than two full terms as President.
- 7.7** Every officer and Director must be an enrolled student and a Voting Member. A candidate for President or Vice President must have been a Member for at least one semester and held a Society role for at least one semester. This requirement is waived for the founding term.
- 7.8** The full duties of each role are set out in the Roles & Staffing Handbook.

Article VIII The Founder

- 8.1** Shaheen Farjo is recognised as the Founder of the Society. The title is honorary and permanent.
- 8.2** For the founding term, from Charter Day until the new Council takes office after the first election in spring 2027, the Founder serves as President. The founding officers and Directors are appointed by the Founder and confirmed by the Founding General Assembly or by the Council.
- 8.3** After the founding term, the Founder holds office only if elected, like any Member. For one year after leaving office the Founder may attend the Council as Founding Advisor, without a vote, to support continuity.

Article IX The Faculty Advisor

- 9.1** The Faculty Advisor is a full-time member of the University's faculty or staff, invited by the Council and confirmed by the Office of Student Life, for a renewable term of one year.
- 9.2** The Faculty Advisor advises the Council, signs approvals where the University requires it, reviews the accounts each semester, and is a first point of contact on sensitive matters. The Faculty Advisor does not vote and does not direct creative or editorial decisions, except on grounds of safety, law or University policy.

Article X Programmes and Committees

- 10.1** Programmes are the Society's ongoing projects. Any Member may pitch one. The Council greenlights a programme with a named lead, a budget and a plan, set out in a Programme Charter.

- 10.2** A programme that runs successfully for two consecutive semesters may be declared a Standing Programme, with a Programme Chair and its own handbook. At the adoption of this Constitution the Standing Programmes are *Waraq* (the journal, working title), *Side Quest* (the video series, working title), *Second Chapter* (the charity book drive) and the *Typewriter Tour*.
- 10.3** Programme Chairs and editors make creative and editorial decisions within their charter. The Council does not overrule a selection except on grounds of law, safety or University policy, and records its reasons in writing.
- 10.4** The standing committees are the Elections Committee, the Conduct Panel and the Audit. The Council may form other committees, each with a written remit and an end date.

Article XI Elections

- 11.1** Officers are elected each year by Voting Members in the spring election, run by an Elections Committee of three Voting Members who are not candidates. The Faculty Advisor observes.
- 11.2** Voting is by secret ballot. Each Voting Member has one vote per office, verified by AUIB sign-in.
- 11.3** Where more than two candidates stand, voting is by ranked choice. Where one candidate stands, members vote to elect the candidate or to re-open nominations.
- 11.4** If an office falls vacant, a by-election is held within four weeks of term, unless fewer than six weeks of the term remain, in which case the Council appoints an interim officer. A vacant Director role is filled by the Executive Board after an open call.
- 11.5** The detailed rules are set out in the Elections Code in the Bylaws.

Article XII Conduct, Discipline and Removal

- 12.1** Every Member agrees to the Code of Conduct in the Policy Manual.

- 12.2** A concern may be raised with any officer, the Faculty Advisor or the Office of Student Life. It is handled confidentially and in proportion under the Complaints and Discipline Procedure, and the person concerned is told of it and may answer before any decision.
- 12.3** A Director may be removed by two-thirds of the Council after a hearing.
- 12.4** An officer may be removed by two-thirds of the votes cast at a General Assembly, on a motion supported by two-thirds of the Council or by a petition of one-fifth of Voting Members. The officer may address the Assembly before the vote.
- 12.5** The Council may declare vacant the seat of a member who misses three Council meetings in one semester without explanation.
- 12.6** Matters that may breach University rules or the law are referred to the Office of Student Life. The Society does not investigate them itself.

Article XIII Finance and Property

- 13.1** The financial year follows the academic year. The Treasurer keeps the accounts. The Council adopts an annual budget and reports it to the General Assembly.
- 13.2** Within an approved budget, a Director may authorise spending up to 50,000 IQD with the Treasurer; spending up to 250,000 IQD requires the President and the Treasurer; spending above 250,000 IQD requires a vote of the Council. University funds follow the procedures of the Office of Student Life.
- 13.3** Cash is counted by two people, is never kept overnight by one student, and is recorded the same day. Every purchase has a receipt. Money raised for a charitable cause is passed in full to the named beneficiary; costs are paid separately.
- 13.4** Equipment, books, the archive, the Society Typewriter, and the Society's name and brand belong to the Society, not to any individual, and are recorded in the inventory.

- 13.5** The accounts are reviewed each semester by the Faculty Advisor or the Audit, and a summary is shared with Members.

Article XIV Records and Transparency

- 14.1** The General Secretary keeps the Constitution, Bylaws and Policies, the minutes and decisions log, the register of Members, correspondence, and the archive, including the Book of Members.
- 14.2** Any Member may see the non-confidential minutes, the budget and the accounts on request within seven days.
- 14.3** Personal data is handled under the Privacy Policy and seen only by those who need it.
- 14.4** The President presents an Annual Report at the Annual General Meeting.

Article XV Bylaws and Policies

- 15.1** The Council may adopt Bylaws and Policies consistent with this Constitution by a two-thirds vote. They are reported to the next General Assembly, which may amend or overturn them by a simple majority.
- 15.2** Where documents conflict, this order prevails: University policy, this Constitution, the Bylaws, the Policies, then handbooks and guides.

Article XVI Amendments

- 16.1** An amendment may be proposed by a majority of the Council or by a petition of one-tenth of Voting Members.
- 16.2** The text is sent to all Members at least fourteen days before the General Assembly that considers it.
- 16.3** An amendment is adopted by two-thirds of the votes cast at a quorate General Assembly.

- 16.4** Sections 1.1, 2.4, 3.1 and 3.4 (the name, non-partisanship, open and free membership, and non-discrimination) may be amended only by two General Assemblies at least thirty days apart.

- 16.5** An amendment takes effect once it is filed with the Office of Student Life, and approved where the University requires. The General Secretary updates the version record.

Article XVII Dissolution

- 17.1** The Society may be dissolved by two-thirds of the votes cast at two General Assemblies at least thirty days apart.
- 17.2** On dissolution, debts are paid first. Remaining funds are used as the final General Assembly decides for a student arts or charitable purpose, within University rules. The archive, the books and the Society Typewriter pass to the University Library, so that the record remains.

Article XVIII Interpretation and Adoption

- 18.1** The President rules on questions of interpretation, subject to the Council. A dispute that the Council cannot settle goes to the Faculty Advisor and, if needed, to the Office of Student Life.
- 18.2** This Constitution is adopted by the Founding Members at the Founding General Assembly on Charter Day and enters into force on adoption, subject to acknowledgement by the Office of Student Life.
- 18.3** For the Founding General Assembly only, the quorum is waived. Every Founding Member present signs the Founders' Roll.

ملخص الدستور

جمعية الفنون والآداب

نحن طلبة الجامعة الأمريكية في العراق – بغداد، المجتمعين في جمعية الفنون والآداب، نعتمد هذا الدستور لتكون جمعيتنا مفتوحة لكل طالب، تُدار بشفافية، وتحرص على الناس والمال، وتبقى بعد مؤسسيها.

الرسالة	تنمية ثقافة الأدب والتعبير الإبداعي في الجامعة.
الشعار	«والقراطس والقلم» — من بيت المتنبي.
العضوية	مفتوحة ومجانية لكل طالب مسجل في الجامعة، دون اختبار أو رسوم. يحق التصويت لمن شارك في نشاطين على الأقل خلال الفصل.
الهيئة العامة	تضم جميع الأعضاء، وتنتخب المسؤولين، وتعُدّل الدستور بأغلبية الثلثين، وتجتمع مرة كل فصل على الأقل.
المجلس	الرئيس ونائبه والأمين العام وأمين الصندوق، وستة مديري: الأدب، والمسرح والفنون، والبرامج والفعاليات، والإعلام، والشراكات، والعضوية والمجتمع.
الانتخابات	سنوياً في نيسان، باقتراع سري عبر حساب الجامعة، تديرها لجنة من غير المرشحين. لا يتولّى أحد الرئاسة أكثر من دورتين.
الاستقلال التحريري	يتخذ المحررون القرارات الإبداعية، ولا يلغيها المجلس إلا لأسباب قانونية أو تتعلق بالسلامة أو بسياسة الجامعة، وبشكل مكتوب.
المال	حدود واضحة للصرف، وشخصان عند كل عدّ للنقد، وإيصال لكل عملية شراء، وتُسَلَّم أموال الأعمال الخيرية كاملةً إلى الجهة المستفيدة.
الحياد	الجمعية غير حزبية وغير طائفية، وتلتزم بسياسات الجامعة.
التأسيس	تُمنح صفة «مؤسس الجمعية» لشاهين فرجو، وتكون الرئاسة في الدورة التأسيسية لشاهين فرجو حتى أول انتخابات في ربيع ٢٠٢٧.

Arabic summary for information. The English text is authoritative (section 1.4). **To be checked by a native Arabic speaker before Charter Day**, including the Arabic name of the Society and the Founder's name in Arabic script.

The Founders' Roll

We, the Founding Members, adopt this Constitution on Charter Day, Tuesday, October 13, 2026, and sign our names to it. This page is kept in the archive for as long as the Society exists.

No.	Full name	College & year	Six words (optional)	Signature
01				
02				
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Continue on a second sheet if needed. Each Founding Member also types six words on the Society Typewriter; the page goes into the Book of Members.

Adoption Record

Completed by the General Secretary at the Founding General Assembly and after each amendment.

DATE ADOPTED**VENUE****FOUNDING MEMBERS PRESENT****VOTES FOR / AGAINST / ABSTAINING**_____
Shaheen Farjo · Founder & President_____
General Secretary_____
Faculty Advisor**ACKNOWLEDGED BY THE OFFICE OF STUDENT LIFE (NAME, DATE, REFERENCE)**

Version record

VERSION**DATE****CHANGE****APPROVED AT****1.0**

Oct 13, 2026

Constitution adopted

Founding General Assembly

DOCUMENT**VERSION****OWNER****APPROVED BY**

SAL-GOV-01

1.0 (draft)

General Secretary

General Assembly

Next review: every April, before the AGM. The current version always lives in *SAL Drive > 01 Governance*; printed copies may be out of date.

Paper and Pen.